

Saint John Chrysostom
Homilies on David and Saul

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HOMILY I

Of David and Saul, and of tolerance, and that it is necessary to spare enemies, and not to speak ill of those who are absent.

1. Whenever any prolonged and severe swelling has stuck to the bodies, then a long time, much labor, and much wisdom are needed in applying remedies, so that the accumulated swelling may be dissolved without danger to life. The same is seen in the soul. For whenever someone wishes to uproot a disease that has already taken root in the soul and has been fixed for a long time, a single or two-day admonition is not enough for correction: rather, this matter must be treated frequently and over many days: only then are we to carry out this office of preacher, not for ambition and pleasure, but for fruit and utility. Therefore, as we did about oaths, having discussed the same subject with you for many days, let us now do the same about anger, and pursue continuous exhortation about it as far as lies in us. For this seems to me to be the best way of teaching, if we do not cease consulting about any matter before we see that the admonition has reached its effect. For he who speaks today of almsgiving, tomorrow of prayer, yesterday of gentleness (humanitate), and then again of modesty of mind, will not be able to accomplish any of these things properly in the minds of his hearers, always jumping from this to that, and again from that to another: but it is necessary that he who wishes his speech to achieve the intended fruit in the minds of his hearers, should not cease from admonishing and advising them about the same things, nor should he jump to something else before he has seen the higher admonition well fixed and rooted in them. The same is what schoolmasters are wont to do:

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they do not bring the children to the syllables until they have seen the knowledge of the elements properly confirmed in them. Recently, therefore, by relating to you the parable of the hundred denarii and the ten thousand talents, we showed how great the evil it was to remember injuries. For he whom ten thousand talents had not ruined was destroyed and drowned by a hundred denarii, and the hundred denarii revoked the pardon granted for debts, and wasted the remission of the money due (Matthew 18:23-35), and dragged him, who had been freed from crimes, back to judgment, and from there threw him into prison, and finally delivered him over to immortal punishment. But today we will attempt to speak of a different subject. For it was necessary, if what was right were to be done, to provide examples of this pre-eminent philosophy, speaking of humanity and meekness, offering from himself examples of that excellent philosophy, and thus at the same time to teach it in words and to instruct in deeds to it. But since we are long absent from this virtue, we will use a certain number of saints brought into the midst, and subject to your eyes, to apply a somewhat clear and powerful exhortation, so that we may urge both you and ourselves, as it were, to the emulation of a certain archetype.

Who then is to be brought forward in the midst of the world to speak of humanity? Who else but he who has deserved to be praised by heavenly testimony, and for this very reason is to be most highly regarded? I have found, he says, David the son of Jesse, a man after my own heart (1 Samuel 13:14; Acts 13:22). Moreover, after God has spoken, there is no occasion left to contradict. His judgment is uncorrupted, because God neither judges from favoritism nor from hatred, but according to the mere virtue of the mind renders his

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verdict. But we have not brought forward this man in the midst of the world only because he was praised by God's suffrage, but also because he is one of those who were brought up under the old law. If under the law of grace there had been someone pure from anger, forgiving the offenses of enemies, and sparing those who had been wronged, it would indeed be nothing surprising, especially after Christ's death, after he had so mercifully forgiven us all our sins, after so many precepts full of evangelical philosophy. But in the Old Testament, when the law permitted an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth (Exodus 21:24), and allowed the injured party to exact talion, that someone should have overstepped the limits of those precepts and reached apostolic philosophy, would he not fill his hearers with wonder? And if we do not imitate him, will we not be deprived of all pardon and excuse? But that you may know his virtue more accurately, grant me to go back over the discourse a little further, and to mention the benefits which that blessed man bestowed on Saul. For it is not surprising if one does not avenge an enemy who has only done a slight injury. But that he should spare a man whom he had enriched with many benefits, and to whom he had returned kindness for kindness, though that man tried once, again, and again—indeed, many times—to kill him, after he had fallen into his hands, when it was already lawful to kill him—not only did he let him go, but also rescued him from the snares of others; especially since he knew that he would afterwards attempt the same thing: what else did he do that can be adjoined to the highest philosophy?

2. But bear with me as I recount briefly what benefits David bestowed on Saul, when and how. When at one time the Jews were oppressed by a most difficult war, so that all were terrified with fear,

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and no one dared to raise his head, but the city was in extreme despair, each one having death before his eyes, and all daily expecting destruction, so that they might lead a life more miserable than those who live in the most terrible prison, this man, coming from the sheep to the army, although he could not learn the art of war through age, and was unaccustomed to military labors, himself took the war upon himself for all, and conducted the matter successfully, beyond what anyone had hoped. Although even if the result had been lacking in virtue, yet he was to be crowned for his readiness of mind and excellent purpose alone. Now if any of the soldiers, being of age, had designed this deed, it would have been nothing surprising, namely, that it was required by military law. But this one, who saw no necessity driving him here, and had many discouraging him: for both his brother rebuked him, and the king, perceiving that he was not yet mature in age, and unfit to bear dangers, restrained him, and ordered him to remain, saying: You cannot go, for you are a boy: but he is a man of war from his youth (1 Samuel 17:33): yet when no occasion provoked him, of his own accord and of himself inflamed with divine zeal, and love of his country, just as if he saw sheep more truly than men, and as if he were going to attack dogs rather than so numerous an army of men, he ran so fearlessly towards the barbarians: and at that time he declared such great solicitude for the king, that even before the battle and victory he raised him up prostrate on his face. For he not only helped him with his deeds, but also with his words, encouraging him to be of good cheer, and persuading him, and so that he might conceive good hopes of the outcome, he effected thus speaking: Let not the heart of my lord be grieved in him, for your

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servant will go and fight with this stranger (1 Samuel 17:52). I ask, does this seem a small thing, compelled by no necessity, to risk his own life, and to rush into the midst of the enemies for the benefit of those from whom he had received no benefits? Was it not fitting, after such a deed, to call him by an ornate title inscribed on the lord's pillars, and to name him the public savior of the city, he who had preserved the glory of the kingdom, the foundations of the cities, and the life of all with God's helping grace? What other benefit could be greater than this? For he did not confer this benefit for glory or power, but for his very life; and he was brought back from the very gates of death. Therefore, if you consider human help, by his benefit the king then lived and preserved his kingdom. And afterwards, what favor did he bestow upon him? For if anyone were to weigh the greatness of the deeds, even if the king had placed the crown taken from his own head on David's head, he would never have returned an equal favor, but he should have received a greater favor. For here he gave him his life and the kingdom, but he was only going to give up the kingdom to him. However, let us consider the favor returned for good deeds. What was that? Moreover, from that day forward Saul suspected David and feared him (1 Samuel 18:6-9). Why and for what reason? For the reason for suspicion must also be mentioned. For not everything someone says is just. For towards him who laid down his life and gave his life, what could be a just cause for suspicion? But let us examine the cause of enmity itself, so that you may learn something, that neither victory itself is inferior: and that David is honorable because of those very things, because of which suspicion has come afterwards, there is a desire for ambushes. What then was the reason for suspicion? After he had

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taken the head of that barbarian, and returned carrying the spoils: "The women came out," he says, "singing and saying, 'Saul has slain his thousands, and David his ten thousands.' And Saul was angry, and he suspected David from that day forward (1 Samuel 18:6-9). For whose sake? Even if these things had been said undeservedly, it was not necessary to bear a hostile mind toward David. But since from David's deeds he had learned his goodwill toward him—since David, with no one compelling or forcing him, had of his own goodwill undergone so great a danger—it was not fitting from then on to suspect any evil of him. Now, however, the praises were rightly spoken; and if it is right to speak the truth, those words were rather for Saul's honor than for David's; yet he should have been satisfied that they had credited him with a thousand. Why then was he indignant that David was given ten thousand? For if the king had thought even a little about ending the war, it would have been rightly said, Saul in his thousands, David in his ten thousand. But if he himself sat at home, fearful and trembling, expecting death every day—while David performed the whole exploit—was it not absurd for him, who had contributed nothing to warding off the dangers, to be indignant because he had not received more praise? For if he was to be indignant, it was rather fitting for David to be indignant, because, since he had done it all alone, he had another to share in the praise.

3. But I say nothing of these: I would say this: that we may grant the women acted wrongly, and that they were liable to ridicule and worthy of accusation. What has this to do with David? For he had not composed the song himself, nor had he urged them to say what they said, nor had he adorned that manner of praise. Therefore, even if it were right to be indignant, it was right to be indignant at the

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women, not at a citizen well-deserved and worthy of endless crowns. But Saul, omitting them, was angry with David. Now if that blessed man, raised up by that praise, had envied the one powerful in affairs, and had been contemptuous of him, and had spurned his authority, perhaps there would have been some cause for envy; but he became more humane and modest, and kept himself in the order of subjects—what then was a just cause for grief? For indeed when he who is honored is exalted against him by whom he was advanced, and does not cease to abuse honor for his contempt, grief has some excuse; but where he persists in honoring him, or rather obeys him all the more and yields in all things, whom can he afterwards have as a pretext for envy? David is not exalted on account of his prosperous success.

Therefore, even if nothing else had been done brilliantly, he was still more to be loved for this very reason, because, when he had found such an opportunity to seize the kingdom, he persisted in his modesty. For it was not only the things that had gone before, but also those that followed, which were much more glorious than those before, that lifted his spirits. What then? David, he says, was prudent in all his ways, and the Lord Almighty was with him, and all Israel and Judah loved David, because he went in and out before the people. And Michal the daughter of Saul, and all Israel loved him. He was wiser than all the servants of Saul; and his name was greatly honored (1 Samuel 18:14, 16, 20, 30). And Jonathan the son of Saul loved David greatly (1 Samuel 18:2). Yet although he had won over the entire people and the king's family, although he was victorious everywhere in war and was never unsuccessful, and although he received such favor for his good deeds, he did not lift his head, nor

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did he covet the kingdom, nor did he avenge himself on his enemy, but persevered in doing good and in waging the king's wars successfully. Who is the fierce and cruel man whom these things would not persuade him to lay down his enmity and cast off his envy? But he did not yield to any of these things; but blind to all this, and given to envy, he tried to remove him from the midst: and what was he doing? (for that is greater and more astonishing,) playing the harp, and calming his own madness. David, he says, played with his hand daily: and a spear was in Saul's hand: and Saul took up a spear, and said, I will thrust it into David; and he fastened it to the wall: and David turned aside from his sackcloth twice (1 Samuel 18:11). Can anything be added to this malice? Perhaps those which followed afterwards. He who had lately driven away the enemies, by whom the city had been restored to him, all sacrificing victims for the victory: Saul attempted to kill the benefactor and savior, and the author of those benefits, while he was playing: and not even the memory of the benefits restrained him, though he was raging and delirious, but once and twice he hurled the spear at him; nor were these the only instances, but besides these there were also other greater things.

5. But none of these things did that just man weigh with himself, considering only this one thing, how he might redeem the crown of tolerance, and practice a certain new and admirable philosophy. For it was not at all surprising if, when he was alone and without companions, he had spared him by whom he had been injured, and now he did the same to others present: for the presence of those soldiers was a double obstacle to philosophy. It often happens to us ourselves, that when we have ceased to remit vengeance and to

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pardon the charges; then, when we see some irritating and inciting us, we change our mind and obey their words. But this did not happen to this blessed man, but even after their advice and exhortation he persevered in his purpose of mind. But not even this alone is worthy of admiration, that he was not moved from his purpose by the admonition of others, and that he did not fear them; but rather that he brought it about that they too took on the same moderation of mind. It is indeed a great thing if one can control one's desires: but it is much greater to be able to persuade others to have the same mind: others, I say, who are neither modest nor temperate men, but soldiers, who had already been driven to despair by many difficulties, from which they desired a little respite, not unaware that not only the entire solution of evils lay in the killing of the enemy; and not only the solution of evils, but also the acquisition of many goods, since nothing prevented the kingdom from passing immediately to David after he was murdered. However, since there were so many things that irritated the soldiers, that noble man was so powerful that he was superior to all of them, and persuaded them to spare their enemies.

It is worth the effort, indeed, to listen to the counsel of the soldiers themselves, because the cunning of their counsel shows the firm and solid mind of a just man. For they did not speak thus: Behold he who has plotted many evils against you, who has desired your death, who has surrounded us with incurable difficulties: but when they saw that David neglected all these things, and did not have much reason for the things committed against him, they allege to him a Divine Author, God, they say, delivered him up (1 Samuel 24:4), that, namely, he might fear the judgment that had proceeded from

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God, and go the more readily to the murder. Will you, they say, take vengeance for yourself? You serve and minister to God, and you approve his judgment. But the more they said these things, the more he spared the enemy, for he understood that God had delivered him up for this purpose, that he might supply himself with greater occasions of proving his virtue. Therefore you also, if ever your enemy falls into your hands, beware of thinking that you have been given an opportunity to avenge him, but rather to preserve the enemy. And then we must most spare our enemies, when they have perhaps come into our power. But here perhaps someone would say: And what is great or wonderful about sparing one whom you have in your power? For many kings and satraps, raised to supreme authority, judged themselves unworthy, at so great a height of royal power, to exact punishment from those by whom they had once been wronged: the very loftiness of power brought about a reason for reconciliation. But in this case you cannot say anything of the kind. For David, having neither been raised to the principality, nor having obtained the kingdom, and having the kingdom in his hands, did not spare him so that no one could be caused to have been relieved of his anger by the greatness of his kingdom: but since he knew that he would be saved, and would himself be thrown into graver dangers, he did not kill him for that very reason. Let us not compare him with them. For since they have a certain and safe pledge of future security, they deserve to spare him; But this man, though he knew that he was sending the enemy to his own destruction, and giving safety to his enemy, yet he did not kill him, and that although he had many driving forces to that murder. For the solitude of the king, deprived of his help, the exhortation of the sword, the memory of the

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past, the fear of the future; the conviction that if he had killed the enemy, he could not be condemned for the killing, and that after the law had been carried out, he seemed to surpass it in meekness, these and many other things urged and compelled him to stab him with the sword. But he yielded to none of these, but persisted like an invincible diamond, preserving the untarnished law of philosophy. And do not say that he felt none of those passions which it was fitting he should feel, or that what happened was not philosophy but stupor; rather consider how strongly, though exasperated, he restrained himself. Indeed, waves of anger had swelled in his mind, and many a storm of thoughts had been stirred up, but that the fear of God had restrained that storm, and had subdued his spirits, may be seen from what happened. He arose, he says, and secretly took the hem of Saul's cloak. Do you see how great a storm of anger had arisen? But he went no further, nor did he cause shipwreck, because the governor, immediately sensing the danger, namely pious reason, turned the storm into calmness. For, he says, it struck David's heart, and like a horse leaping and raging, it recalled his anger (1 Samuel 24:4-6).

6. The souls of the saints are of this kind: before they fall, they rise again, before they reach sin, they are restrained, because they are sober, and always watchful. And yet how great was the distance between the body and the garment? Yet he restrained himself, lest he should go further: and moreover for this very reason he severely condemned himself. For, he says, his heart smote him, because he had taken away the hem of his cloak, and said to the men: Far be it from the Lord (1 Samuel 24:6). What is that, Far be it from the Lord? he says, be it to me, if I had willed this: may God never

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permit me to do this, nor permit me to come to such a state. Since he saw that this philosophy almost surpassed human nature, and that he needed heavenly help, and that he had almost gone to murder, he prays that the Lord would keep his hand undefiled. What could be milder to this mind? Shall we call this man a man who in human nature lived an angelic life? But the divine laws will not allow that. For who would easily ask such a thing from God? What did I say, such a thing? Who would endure not to pray against him who had been a troublemaker? For most mortals are so taken with savagery that, when they are so weak that they are unable to do any harm to the one by whom they have been harassed, they call upon God for vengeance, that he may give them the power to harm those who have brought evil upon them. But here, praying as if diametrically opposed to all of them, he begs that he not permit him to lay hands on him, speaking in this manner: Let not this happen to me from the Lord, that I should lay my hand on him (1 Samuel 24:6): just as he speaks of a son and of an offspring, so he speaks of an enemy.

He did not only spare Saul, but also prepared an excuse for him. See indeed how prudently and wisely. For when, examining the life of Saul, he had found nothing good, so that he could say he was not injured by him, nor suffered any inconvenience (for the soldiers who were present were about to complain about this, and had known the king's wickedness by experience), he went around on the other side, trying to find a probable excuse. When he could not do this, neither from his life nor from his deeds, he took refuge in his dignity, saying: Because he is the Lord's anointed (1 Samuel 24:6). What do you mean? they say. That he is a criminal, that he is covered with crimes, and filled with innumerable vices, and thinks the worst of

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us? But he is a king, but a prince, and he has assumed a principality over us. And yet he did not say, he is a king, but, he is the Lord's Christ, not from human honor, but from the honorable testimony received from the heavenly judgment. Do you despise, he says, your fellow servant? Reverence for the Lord. Do you despise the chosen one? Fear him who has chosen. For if we fear and awe these ordinary prefects appointed by the Emperor, even if they are wicked, if they are thieves, if they are robbers, if they are unjust, if they are anything else, we fear and awe them, not because we despise them for their wickedness, but because we revere the dignity of him by whom they were chosen: much more is it fitting to do so towards those whom God has chosen. God has not yet, he says, deprived him of his principality, he has not yet deprived him of his kingship. Therefore let us not invert the order, nor fight with God, fulfilling by our deeds that apostolic saying: For whoever resists the power resists the ordinance of God; and whoever resists will receive damnation to himself (Romans 13:2). He not only called him Christ, that is, anointed king; but he also called him his lord. It is not mediocre philosophy to call an enemy of honor and obedience by the terms of honor. And again, how great this is, someone can see from what happens to others. Most people do not even bear to call their enemies by their bare and simple names, but call them by other hateful terms: impious, insane, possessed, mad, pestilent: they combine many other things, and designate the enemy with these characteristics. I will show that this is true, by an example not sought from afar, but taken from the nearest, namely from this same Saul, who, because of his vehement hatred, could not bear to call this just man by his own name, but when a certain feast was being

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celebrated, he inquired, saying, Where is the son of Jesse (1 Samuel 20:27)? But he called him thus partly out of hatred of his own name, partly out of recognition of the meanness of his father, hoping that by this agreement the reputation of the just would be defiled: not understanding that a man is usually made noble and illustrious, not by the renown of his ancestors, but by the virtue of his mind. But blessed David did not do the same. For he did not call him by his father's surname, although he too was very humble and despised: nor did he designate him by a bare and simple name, but by a title of dignity and principality. So pure was his mind from all malevolence. Therefore, you too, my dearest, imitating him, learn first of all never to call your enemy by hateful names, but rather by honorable ones. For if the mouth has accustomed itself to call him who has injured you by names of honor and service, the mind, hearing this, will not shrink from returning to favor with him, having been taught by the tongue. For the very words will be the best remedy for the ulcer swelling in the heart.

7. I have spoken these things now, not only that we may praise David, but that we may also envy him. Therefore let each one picture this story in his own heart, constantly drawing in his mind with contemplation as with a hand that double cave, Saul himself sleeping inside, and bound by sleep as with a chain, subject to him whom he had most grievously wounded by the right hand; David looming over him as he slept, the soldiers present, and exhorting him to the slaughter; the blessed one philosophizing, that is, restraining his own and their anger, and excusing him who had sinned so much. Let us not only picture these things in our minds, but let us also speak them constantly in our meetings: let us

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frequently renew these narratives with our wives, these with our children. For whether you wish to speak of the king, behold the king: whether of the soldiers, or of family affairs, or of public and civil affairs, you will see in the Scriptures a great abundance of all these. Such commemorations bring the greatest benefit. For it is impossible, I say, impossible, for a mind engaged in such stories to be overcome by desires. Therefore, lest we waste time uselessly, nor waste our lives in vain in foolish and superfluous trifles, let us learn the deeds of brave men, and discuss them constantly. But if anyone in the assembly wishes to speak either about spectacles, or about the running of horses, or about things that have nothing to do with you, make him recall them from that matter, and introduce them into such a narrative, by which at the same time, with purified souls and pleasure that is free from danger, delighted, and finally made gentle and placable towards all those who have done us wrong, we may depart from this life, having no enemy in the world to come, and may obtain eternal goods, through the grace and goodness of our Lord Jesus Christ, to whom be glory forever. Amen.

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That it is a great good, not only to exercise virtue, but also to praise it: and that David erected a more magnificent trophy by sparing Saul than for having laid Goliath low: and that in doing this he benefited himself more than Saul: and of his apology to Saul.

1. It is profitable to praise those endowed with virtue. You indeed recently praised David for his endurance of evils; I, on the other hand, admired your benevolence and affection for David. For one must not only approach and emulate virtue, but also exalt with praise those who embrace virtue and proclaim them admirable; this brings us some fruit, and that is not ordinary: just as on the contrary, not only to emulate wickedness, but also to praise those who live in it, prepares for us no mean punishment: and if it is permissible to say something new and admirable, a heavier punishment awaits them than those who live badly. Paul, declaring this, after he had enumerated every kind of wickedness, and accused all who trample upon the laws of God, adds concerning them: Who, knowing the justice of God, that they which commit such things are worthy of death, not only do them, but also approve them that commit them: therefore you are inexcusable, O man (Romans 1:32; Romans 2:1). You see him speaking in such a way as to show that this is more grievous than that. For to praise offenders, which pertains to punishment, is far more than to offend: and rightly so, because this endorsement proceeds from a mind that is utterly corrupt, and suffering from an incurable disease. For he who, while sinning, condemns his sin, may at some time, in the course of time, return to himself; but he who praises wickedness, has deprived himself of the

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cure which repentance brings. Therefore Paul rightly pronounced this to be more grievous than that. Therefore, just as not only those who do evil, but also those who praise and preach such, receive the same, or even heavier, punishment: so those who praise and preach good people become partakers of the crowns reserved for them. That this is so is evident from Scripture. For God thus speaks to Abraham: I will bless those who bless you, and I will curse those who curse you (Genesis 12:3). Anyone will see the same thing happen in the Olympic competitions. For it is not only the athlete who wears the crown, nor the one who has endured labor and sweat, but even he who praises the victor, reaps no small pleasure from his praise. Therefore, I do not only declare that generous and magnanimous man blessed for his philosophy of mind, but you also for your kind spirit towards him. And he fought and conquered, and took the crown: but you, because you praised the victory, took no small part of the crown for yourselves. So that this pleasure may be more abundant for you, and the fruit more abundant, let us now also explain the remaining parts of this history to you. When the writer of the history had mentioned the words with which David condemned the murder, he added: He did not allow them to rise up and kill Saul (1 Samuel 24:8), wishing to demonstrate both their minds ready for murder and his fortitude. But many indeed who seem to be philosophizing, even if they themselves do not accept murder, nevertheless do not restrain others who are preparing murder. But not David, but just as if he had accepted something on his side, for which he would have to give an account, not only did he not touch the enemy, but he also restrained others who wanted to kill him, becoming an excellent attendant and a bodily guardian for his

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enemy. Therefore it is not beside the point to say that David at that time fell into a more serious crisis than Saul himself. For he did not endure a light conflict or struggle, while he strove in every way to keep Saul from the murder the soldiers were plotting: nor did he fear being killed so much as he feared that one of the soldiers, obeying his anger, would kill the man: and for this reason he invented an excuse of this kind. The soldiers were urging accusation, and Saul lay helpless in his sleep, but David defended his enemy, but God was the judge, and confirmed the sentence of David. For without the protection of God he would not have been able to overcome those furious men: but there was the grace of God residing on the lips of the prophet, which added a certain charm to his words. Yet David also contributed no small weight to this, who, since he had so instructed them at an earlier time, therefore found them ready and obedient at the critical moment of the struggle. For he had presided over them not as a war-leader over soldiers, but as a priest, and that assembly was already well established.

Thus, just as someone who had obtained the office of bishop would preach to them, and after the sermon was finished offered a sacrifice, and that a certain admirable and incredible thing, not by slaying a calf, or by killing a lamb, but by what was much more honorable than these, offering meekness and humanity to God, and by slaying the irrational impulse of the mind, and by killing anger, and by mortifying the members which are upon the earth. And he himself became both a victim, and a sacrifice, and an altar (Colossians 3:5). For both the reason which offered meekness and humanity, and the humanity and meekness itself, and finally the heart in which these were offered, were all the same man.

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2. After he had offered this splendid sacrifice, he then carried off the victory and omitted nothing that belonged to the trophy; when these contests were over, Saul at last rose and came out of the cave, unaware of all that had been done. David also came out after him (1 Samuel 24:9), lifting his eyes, now free, to heaven, and rejoicing more at that moment than when he had laid Goliath low and cut off the barbarian's head. For this victory was more magnificent, these spoils more magnificent, this booty more illustrious, this trophy more glorious. For there he needed sling, stones, and weapons of war; but here everything was accomplished by prudence and reason, victory came without arms, and a bloodless trophy was raised. So he returned bearing not that barbarian's head, but a stilled spirit and enfeebled anger; nor did he store these spoils in Jerusalem, but in heaven and in that city above. Now women did not come out to meet him with dances and praises, but the host of angels applauded from on high, admiring his philosophy and humanity. For he ascended with the enemy wounded by innumerable blows, as one who, although he had saved Saul, nevertheless pierced that true enemy, the devil, with many wounds. For when we fight one another in anger and clash in mutual strife, he rejoices and exults; but when we live in peace and concord and restrain our anger, he is bound and cast down—the enemy of peace, the foe of concord, and the father of envy. So David went out bearing that right hand, worth as much as the whole world, crowned together with his head. For just as emperors often crown, before the head, the right hand of a boxer or pancratiast who has fought nobly in the ring, so God crowned the hand that could draw a pure sword, show God a blade unstained by any blood, and withstand so great a storm of wrath. He did not go

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out bearing Saul's diadem, but wearing a crown of righteousness; he did not go out in the king's purple robe, but clothed in a humanity surpassing human nature, a garment more splendid than any robe.

He came out of the cave with as much glory as the three boys came out of the burning furnace. For as the fire did not burn them, so he was not consumed by the blaze of anger. For them, the fire in which they stood did no harm from without (Daniel 3); but here, although he had coals burning within, and without the devil was fanning the furnace—from the sight of the enemy, from the soldiers' urging, from the ease of finishing the deed, from the solitude of those who might help Saul, from memory of past wrongs, from fear of future dangers (for these things, together with brushwood, pitch, stubble, and all the rest with which that Babylonian furnace was fed, stirred a brighter flame)—yet David did not burst into flame, nor was he moved as anger would naturally have moved him; but he came out pure, and when he looked upon the enemy's face he especially took on a bold and philosophical spirit. For when he saw him sleeping, remaining motionless, unable to do anything, he spoke with his own soul: Where is that fury now? Where that malice? Where all those schemes, all those snares? All of them are gone; they perished at the onset of a little sleep. The king lies bound, though we have planned and done none of these things. He gazed at him sleeping and reflected on death, which is common to all. For sleep is nothing else than a temporary death and a daily dying. It is not out of place here to recall Daniel as well. For just as he came up from the den after conquering the wild lions (Daniel 14), so this man came out of the cave after conquering beasts far more savage. For as lions sat on either side of that just man, so passions fiercer and stronger than any

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lions assailed this one—on one side indignation over the past, on the other fear of the future; yet he restrained them both, shutting the beasts' mouths, teaching by his deeds that nothing is safer than sparing an enemy, and nothing more dangerous than wishing to avenge oneself and exact vengeance. The other man, who had plotted attack, lay naked and unarmed, stripped of every help, no differently than a captive delivered into his enemy's hands; but this man, while he yielded and gave way everywhere, and would not even lay hands on him though he had just cause—without engines, without arms, without cavalry, without soldiers—took the enemy into his power; and greatest of all, he made God more favorably disposed toward himself.

3. How much profit David made by saving Saul. Much greater is it to spare than to destroy. For I do not call that holy man blessed because he saw the enemy lying at his feet, but because he spared him when he was given into his hands. Of these the former was the work of divine power, the latter of his philosophy. How reasonably the soldiers thereafter regarded him, and with what goodwill they were disposed toward him! For if they had had a thousand lives, would they not readily have spent them for their leader—already, from the reverence he showed the enemy, having learned in deed how benevolent he was toward his own? For he who was gentle and meek toward those who troubled him will be much more so toward those who showed him kindness; and that was surely his greatest pledge of security. But they were not only more well-disposed toward him, but also readier against the enemy, because they knew they had God as their champion, always present to their leader, watching over all his actions. Therefore they later obeyed David, not

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as a man, but as an angel. And so David, even before God paid him his reward, received even in this life a greater prize and a more illustrious victory by sparing Saul than if he had slaughtered him. For what profit would he have gained by killing an enemy, compared with what he now gained by sparing him? Weigh these things with yourself, then, when you have taken the man who wronged you: it is far greater and more profitable to spare than to destroy. For he who kills an enemy often condemns himself too, bearing a guilty conscience, afflicted day by day and hour by hour by that pressing sin; but he who spares, and in a short time masters his passions, afterward rejoices and exults, upheld by the best hope and expecting from God the rewards of patience. And if he should ever fall into any trouble, he will ask a great reward from God with confidence—as David here afterward received great and wonderful rewards from God for the reverence he showed his enemy. But let us see what follows. David went out of the cave after Saul and called after him, saying: My lord the king. Saul looked behind him; and David, bowing low, fell on his face to the ground and did him homage (1 Samuel 24:9). These things bring David no less honor than the enemy he saved. For it was no common spirit—not to be puffed up by benefits shown a neighbor, nor to act as most of the crowd do, who like slaves with raised brows despise those they have benefited. Not so the blessed David; rather, after his generous deeds he appeared still more modest. The reason was that he credited none of his fine achievements to his own industry, but ascribed them all to God's gift. Therefore the one who had saved also adored the one saved, again calling him king and himself a servant—repressing the swelling of his heart because of Saul's dignity, calming his anger,

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and putting envy away. Let us hear his defense as well. Why do you listen to the words of the people who say, Behold, David seeks your life (1 Samuel 24:10)? Yet the writer of this history had said before that the whole people were with David, that he was favored in the sight of the king's servants, and that the prince's son and the whole army were devoted to David in heart (2 Samuel 18:16, 22, 28; 19:1). How then does he say here that some falsely accused him and incited Saul against him? Because the writer had shown that Saul did not wage this war against the just man at others' prompting, but from his own mind, when he said that envy was born from David's praises and grew day by day (1 Samuel 18:9-29). Why then did David shift the blame to others, saying, Why do you listen to your people's words, Behold, David seeks your life? Clearly to give Saul a way to shake off his malice. Parents often do the same with children: when someone rebukes a corrupt son who has done many wrongs, though convinced the boy fell into wicked ways through his own malice, he often blames others, saying, I know this was not your fault; others corrupted and led you astray—their sin entirely. Hearing this, the son may little by little recover and return more easily to a good life, ashamed and blushing to seem unworthy of such praise. Paul did likewise writing to the Galatians: after long discourses and unmentionable accusations, at the letter's end, wishing to lift blame from them so that, refreshed a little from their faults, they might reach an excuse, he says: I have confidence in you that you will think nothing else; but he who troubles you will bear judgment, whoever he is (Galatians 5:10). David did the same: when he says, Why do you listen to the people saying, Behold, David seeks your life? he hints that others provoke and poison Saul's mind,

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striving by every means to offer him a path of excuse. Then pleading his own case he says: Behold, your eyes have seen today that the Lord gave you into my hands in the cave, that I would not kill you but spared you, and said, I will not lay my hand on my lord, for he is the Lord's anointed (1 Samuel 24:11). They, he says, slander in words; but I clear myself in deed and drive off the charge by the facts themselves. I need no words when the outcome of events can teach you more clearly than any speech who they are, how I stand, and how the false report and slander arose against me. For these things I call no other witness than yourself—you, who have been preserved by my kindness.

4. But how could Saul be a witness to these things—he who, when they happened, was asleep, and neither heard the words, nor saw David there at the time, nor heard him speaking with the soldiers? How then were they to secure a clear proof? If David had called witnesses, Saul would have distrusted their testimony and thought they spoke in favor of the just man. If he had tried to clear himself by reasoning and plausible arguments, he would have been less believed, since the judge's mind was already corrupted. For how could Saul—who, though he had received so many benefits, still waged war against a man who deserved none—suspect that someone wronged would spare the wrongdoer when he had him in his power? The crowd often judges others by its own standard: the habitual drunkard hardly believes anyone lives soberly; the brothel-goer thinks even the chaste are dissolute; the thief of others' goods is not easily persuaded that some also give away their own. Likewise Saul, once mastered by anger, would not readily have believed a man could be so far above his passions as not only to do

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no harm, but even to save the one who had harmed him. Since the judge's mind was corrupt, and witnesses if produced would have been suspect, by prudent counsel David found a proof that could stop the mouths even of the shameless. What was it? The skirt of the cloak, which he held out and said: See the skirt of your cloak in my hand, which I cut off and did not kill you (1 Samuel 24:12). A mute witness, yet clearer than any who speak. For unless I had stood close, he says, right beside your body, I could not have cut off part of your garment. Do you see how much good came from David's being stirred at first? If he had not been moved to anger, we would not have known the man's philosophy (for most would have thought he spared Saul from shock, not from virtue), nor would he have cut the cloak; and if he had not cut it, he could not have made his other arguments credible to his enemy. But now, since he was stirred and did cut it, he gave the surest proof of his foresight. Therefore, having offered so true and sure a testimony, he at once made Saul judge and witness of the reverence he showed him, saying: Know and see today that there is no wrong in my hand and no contempt for you; you may bind my life and take it (1 Samuel 24:11). Here especially one must admire his magnanimity, that he bases his defense only on what happened that day. He hints at this when he says, Know and see today. I speak of nothing before today; this day is proof enough for me. Though he could have listed many great favors he had done Saul—could have recalled the single combat with the barbarian and said: When barbarian war like a flood was about to destroy the whole city, while you were dismayed and trembling with fear, expecting death daily, I came forward though no one compelled me; indeed you held me back, saying, You cannot go, for you are a boy,

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and he is a warrior from his youth (1 Samuel 17:33)—I did not hold back, but sprang forward alone for all, met the enemy, cut off his head, and like a torrent beat back those barbarians' assault and steadied the tottering state; through me you hold kingdom and life, while all the rest hold, besides life, city, homes, children, and wives. He could have mentioned that trophy again and other brave, successful wars no less than these; also that though Saul once, twice, indeed often tried to remove him and hurled a spear at his head, he does not recall the wrongs; and that after those deeds, when Saul owed the reward for the first battle, he demanded a dowry—not gold or silver, but slaughter and bloodshed—and David did not refuse even that. He could have said not only these but far more; yet he said none of them, nor wished to reproach Saul with benefits, but only to persuade him that he was among those who loved and honored him, not those who plotted rebellion or treachery.

Therefore, having set aside all those matters, he brought into his defense only what had happened that day. He was utterly pure, immune from all empty glory, and looked to nothing but the will of God alone. Then he said: May the Lord judge between me and you (1 Samuel 24:13). He said this not because he wished to punish Saul or take vengeance on him, but to strike fear into him by recalling the judgment to come—not only to strike that fear, but to clear himself from suspicion of wrongdoing. The main proof, he says, I have from the deeds themselves; and if you do not believe, I call God himself as witness, who knows the secrets of every mind and can search hearts.

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5. He said these things, showing that he would never have dared to appeal to that Judge who cannot be deceived, or draw condemnation on himself, unless he were fully sure he was clear of every charge of treachery. That we do not speak from conjecture—but that, wishing both to clear himself and to call Saul back to sobriety, he mentioned that judgment—the things already done show clearly enough; and what happened afterward can confirm it no less. For when Saul again fell into his hands, after David had spared his life, Saul pursued him and sought to kill him; and though David could have destroyed his enemy with the whole army, he sent him away unharmed. Knowing the king's sickness was incurable and that Saul would never cease to be hostile, David withdrew from his sight and lived among the Philistines, in service, stripped of honor, covered with shame, earning his bread by toil and hardship. Yet we marvel not only at this, but that when he heard the king had fallen in battle, he tore his garments, sprinkled himself with ashes, and mourned as one mourns a firstborn, a true son; then, crying aloud his name together with his son's, composing laments too and giving voice to bitter grief, he fasted until evening, cursing even the places that drank Saul's blood. Mountains of Gilboa, he says, let no dew or rain fall on you—mountains of death, for there the shields of the mighty were cast down (2 Samuel 1:21). As fathers often shun their house and gaze in grief on the threshold through which they carried out their son, so he devoted those mountains that received that slaughter. I hate, he says, the very place because of the dead fallen there. Be not watered henceforth by heaven's rains, since you were ill watered once with my friends' blood. He repeated their names again and again: Saul and Jonathan, beloved and lovely—in life not divided, in

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death not parted (2 Samuel 1:23). Since he could not embrace their bodies in absence, he clung to their names, easing his grief as he could and lightening the weight of the disaster. Many thought the sorrow beyond healing; he turned to this very comfort—that both fell on the same day. His words, In life not divided, in death not parted, meant only to console his grief: now, he says, one cannot say the son laments orphanhood or the father bereavement; what befalls no one befell them—snatched from life the same day, neither outliving the other. He thought life would be bitter if they had been torn apart. Are you moved now? Do you weep now? Is your soul troubled? Have your eyes turned to tears? Let each remember the enemy who wronged him, pain still burning within, and spare him living and mourn him dead—not for show, but from the soul and a true heart; and though he must bear hardship, lest he wrong the man who injured him, let him do and suffer all things, expecting great rewards from God. See: he gained the kingdom yet did not stain his hands with blood; with a pure right hand he was crowned, he ascended the throne, wearing a praise more splendid than purple and diadem—namely, that he spared his enemy and mourned that same man dead. Therefore he is honored in men's memory alive and dead. If you desire lasting glory here and solid goods there, imitate this just man's virtue, emulate his way of life, and show in deeds this patience under wrongs, so that sharing his labors you may share his rewards. May we all obtain them, by the grace and goodness of our Lord Jesus Christ, to whom with the Father and the Holy Spirit be glory, power, honor, now and always and forever. Amen.

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That it is dangerous to attend the spectacles, and that they make men perfect adulterers, from which sadness and contention arise; also that David surpassed every kind of forbearance in what he did toward Saul; finally, that to bear plunder with equanimity is no less a virtue than to give alms.

1. Indeed, I think many of those who recently deserted us and went off to wicked spectacles are here today. I would like to know them openly, so I may bar them from the sacred courts—not so they wander outside forever, but so that corrected they may return. Fathers often drive disobedient sons from the house and keep them from the table, not so they remain shut out forever, but so that, improved by discipline, they may come back to their father's home with fitting praise and honor. Shepherds do likewise when they separate scab-infested sheep from the healthy, so that, healed of their wretched disease, they may safely rejoin the flock, lest the sick infect the whole herd. We wished to know these men; and though we cannot spot them with bodily eyes, the Word will know them through and through, and their conscience, once rebuked, will readily persuade them to leave of their own free will, teaching that only he is truly within who has a mind worthy of this fellowship. On the contrary, whoever lives corruptly yet shares in this holy assembly—even if his body stands here—is cast out more truly than those shut outside, who are not yet allowed to share the sacred table. Those expelled by divine law and kept outside still have good hope: if they wish to amend the faults for which the Church cast them out, they may return with a clean conscience. But those who condemn

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themselves, and after being warned not to enter until they have cleansed the stain of their sins then act shamelessly, make the soul's wound and ulcer harsher and deeper. It is not so bad to sin as to act shamelessly after sinning, or to disobey priests who command otherwise. What, they say, have these men done so wrong that they must be barred from the sacred enclosure? What worse crime do you want than men who, though plainly defiled by adultery, rush shamelessly like rabid dogs to this holy table? If you wish to know what adultery is, I will not give my words but his who will judge every life: Whoever looks at a woman to desire her has already committed adultery with her in his heart (Matthew 5:28). If a woman meets you in the market, plainly dressed, and her face alone makes you stare—what of those who go there not casually or by accident, but on purpose, with such zeal that they even despise the Church; who spend the whole day sitting there with eyes fixed on fallen women's faces—how can they claim they did not look to lust? There are added suggestive, lewd words, harlots' signals, voices shaped for pleasure, eyes painted with kohl, cheeks colored, dress artfully arranged, the whole body a show of cosmetics, and many other baits to trap onlookers; the audience's moral slackness, and much confusion; the place itself inviting lust—both from the shows before and those after. Pipe and flute and every like music entice to sin, soften the mind's strength, prepare the souls of those who sit there for harlots' snares and pleasures, and make them easier prey. If here—where there are psalms, prayers, exposition of Scripture, fear of God, and much devotion—lust often steals in secretly like a cunning thief, how can those who sit in the theater, who hear and see nothing wholesome but are steeped in filth and vice, besieged

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through ears and eyes, overcome evil desire? If they cannot, how can they be free of adultery? And if they are not free of adultery, how can they approach these sacred courts without repentance and share in this noble assembly?

2. Wherefore I exhort and beseech you that you first purge yourselves, by confession and penance and every other remedy, of the sin contracted from theatrical spectacles, and only then hear divine sermons. For we sin no small offense in this—as anyone can plainly see from examples. If a servant were to put a slave's tunic, filthy and full of lice, into a chest where his master's precious gold garments are stored, tell me, would you bear that insult patiently? Or if someone poured dung and filth into a golden jar always used for perfumes, would you not beat the man who did this wickedness? Shall we take such care for chests and vessels, clothes and perfumes, and think our soul cheaper than all these—and where the Spirit's ointment is poured in, bring in there devilish pageants, Satan's tales, songs full of whorish (*meretriciae*) shame? Tell me, how will God bear these things? Yet the gap between perfume and filth, between a master's robe and a slave's tunic, is not so great as that between the Spirit's grace and this wicked conduct. Do you not fear, O man—while with the eyes with which you gaze at the couch in the orchestra, where detestable adulterous plays are staged, you look with those same eyes at this sacred table where awful mysteries are celebrated; while with the same ears you hear a harlot speak obscenely and prophet and apostle lead you into Scripture's secrets; while with one heart you swallow deadly poison and this holy, fearful sacrifice? Are not these life's overthrow, marriage's ruin, wars and battles and quarrels at home? When, after those shows, you

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come home more dissolute, softer, more wanton, an enemy of all modesty, your wife's face will please you less, however good she is. Inflamed by the lust you drank in at the theater, and snared by that alien spectacle that maddened you, you despise your chaste, modest wife and life's companion, insult her, heap countless reproaches on her—not because she gives you any cause, but because you are ashamed to confess the disease, ashamed to show the wound you got in the spectacles and brought home; you invent other excuses, seek unfair grounds for quarrel, loathe all you have at home, and crave the wicked, unclean desire that wounded you—while the voice's echo, the looks, the gestures, and all those images of harlot's lust stay in your mind, you take pleasure in nothing at home. Why speak of wife or household, when later you will visit the church itself less gladly, and hear sermons on chastity and modesty with disgust? For what is preached to you is no longer teaching but accusation, and will little by little drive you to despair; in the end you will cut yourself off from the discipline ordained for everyone's good. Therefore I beg you all to shun wicked lingering at spectacles yourselves, and to pull back others led away by them. For whatever happens there is not amusement, but ruin, penalty, and torment. What good is brief pleasure, when endless grief comes from it, and night and day, goaded by lust, you are a burden and hateful to everyone? Shake yourself free, and consider what you are like coming back from church, and what from the spectacles; compare these days with those—do that, and our sermon will be needless. It will be enough to compare this day with that to show how great the profit here, how great the harm there. I thought these things should now be said to your charity, and I will never stop saying them. So

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we shall warn those liable to this disease and strengthen the healthy: this discourse will help both—the one to stop, the other not to fall in. But since rebuke must be moderate, here we end the warning and finish what remains of the topic above, returning to David. Painters' custom is this: when they wish to finish a lifelike portrait, they sit one, two, or three days beside their subjects, so by steady gazing they may shape the likeness without error and exact. Since our aim today is to paint for you not bodily form but the soul's beauty and spiritual grace, we want David himself present with you, so that all, looking at him, may call to mind the just man's portrayed beauty, his gentleness, magnanimity—in sum, all his virtue. If bodily images give viewers some comfort, mental images will do so far more. Those you may not view just anywhere; you must stay in one place. This one nothing hinders you from carrying wherever you will. Once you store it in the mind's inner chamber, wherever you are you may often contemplate it and gain much good. As those with weak eyes, holding sponges and blue cloths, often gaze at them and get some easing of their ailment from that color—so you, if you keep David's image before you and fix your eyes on it steadily, even if anger of the mind strikes the eye a thousand times, by looking to this pattern of virtue you will win perfect healing and a pure philosophy of soul.

3. No enemy is worse than Saul. Let no one say to me: I have an enemy who is wicked, base, corrupt, incorrigible. Whatever you say, he is still not worse than Saul—who, though saved once, twice, nay often by David, while he himself had laid ambushes in a thousand ways, yet for all those benefits received persevered in his malice. What then can you charge your enemy with? That he took part of

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your land, wronged you in the fields, crossed your property line, seized your slaves, used violence, occupied what was yours unlawfully, reduced you to poverty? Yet he has not taken your life, as Saul tried to do. If he even tried to take your life, perhaps he dared it once—not once, twice, thrice, or often as Saul did. If he tried once, twice, thrice, or more often, still he did not receive from you so many kindnesses, nor fall once and again into your hands and be spared. Even if that too happened, David again surpasses you. For it is not the same thing for one living under the old law and for one now, after the Gospel's grace, to forgive such offenses freely. David had not heard the parable of the ten thousand talents and the hundred denarii; had not heard the prayer, Forgive men their debts, as your heavenly Father does (Mark 11:25); had not seen Christ crucified, nor his precious blood poured out, nor heard countless sermons on this way of life; had not shared such a sacrifice or the Lord's blood, but was raised on less perfect laws that demanded nothing like this—yet he reached the height of Gospel virtue. But you, often angry, keep the memory of wrongs. Here, when David feared for the future, knowing well that if he spared the enemy he would be driven from the city and live a wretched life, he still did not stop caring for him, but did everything—nurturing such an enemy against himself. Who can tell of greater patience than this? Moreover, so that you may learn—not only from the past but from what happens now—that you can be reconciled with any man who bears you ill will: what is fiercer than a lion? Yet men make him tame and gentle, by art overcoming nature; the fiercest, proudest beast becomes gentler than any sheep, so that it walks through the marketplace frightening no one. What excuse shall we have, what

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pardon shall we win, if we tame wild beasts yet deny that men can ever be appeased and made well-disposed toward us? For beasts, to be tame is against nature; for man, savagery is against nature. When we overcome nature in them, with what face shall we excuse ourselves if we plead that a man's will cannot be corrected? If you still argue, I say this: though a man suffers an incurable disease, the more toil you spend, the greater your reward—if you sit by him, caring for one stricken with an incurable disease.

Let us therefore look to this one thing—not that we suffer no harm from enemies, but that we do them no harm: thus we shall suffer no harm, even if we endure countless wrongs; just as David, while he was driven out, sent into exile, hunted by plots to the very danger of his life, suffered nothing bitter, but rather through his enemy became more renowned and honored, and dearer to everyone—not only to men but to God himself. For what loss did that holy man take when he suffered so much from Saul? Is he not sung as glorious to this day on earth, more glorious in heaven? Do not indescribable blessings and the kingdom of heaven remain his? Again, what gain did that unhappy wretch win, after laying so many snares? Was he not shaken from his kingdom? Did he not die a pitiable death with his son, and is he not reproached by all (1 Samuel 31)? What is heavier still, he pays eternal punishment. Finally, what do you charge him with—why will you not be reconciled with him? Did he seize your money? If you bear the robbery bravely, you will receive just as much reward as if you had placed it in the poor's hands. For both he who gave to the needy and he who endured the man who seized another's goods neither lays snares nor prays evilly; both act for God's sake. Since the outlay is the same, it is clear there will be one

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and the same crown. But he plotted against your life and tried to kill you? That will be reckoned to you as martyrdom—if, when he was laying snares and had pushed hostility so far, you are counted among those who have done well, not ceasing to pray for him, begging God to be merciful to him.

4. Let us not reckon only that God forbade Saul to kill David, but consider that from Saul's snares he was crowned with a triple and quadruple martyrdom crown. For he who for God's sake spared his enemy—him who once, twice, nay often had shaken a spear at his head—when he had power to kill yet spared him, knowing he would afterward be attacked by him again: clearly he was slain a thousand times by his soul's resolve; and slain a thousand times for God, he won many martyrdom crowns. As Paul says, I die daily (1 Corinthians 15:31); David too suffered the same for God's sake. When he could have removed the enemy plotting against him, he would not, for God's sake, and chose to face danger daily rather than free himself from so many deaths by the right to kill. If it is not lawful to take vengeance on or hate one who plots against you even to the risk of your life, much less may you avenge one who has only injured you in some ordinary way.

To many, being afflicted with insults by enemies, or being brought under suspicion, seems harder to bear than any death. Come then, let us weigh this. Has someone cursed you, called you adulterer and fornicator? If he speaks truly, correct yourself; if falsely, laugh it off; if you are conscious of what is charged, come to your senses; if not, despise it—nay, rather, not only do not mock and scorn the accuser, but rejoice and exult, as the Lord commands. When, he

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says, they revile you and say every evil word against you, lying, rejoice and exult, for your reward is rich in heaven (Matthew 5:11-12). And again, Rejoice and exult when men cast out your name as evil, lying (Luke 6:22-23). But when the reviler has spoken truth and you bear his words modestly—not returning insult or reproach, but sighing bitterly and condemning your faults—you will receive no smaller reward than in the first case. I shall try to prove this from Scripture, so you may see that friends, when they praise and speak to please, do not help you as much as enemies do when they blame—even speaking truth—provided we use their accusations as we ought. For friends often flatter to curry favor; enemies, on the other hand, drag faults into the open. Since we do not see our own sins because of self-love, they, through hatred, see them better than we and drive us by reproach to need correction—so their enmity becomes our greatest gain, not only because we learn our errors when they rebuke us, but because we lay them aside. If an enemy reproaches you for a fault you know, and you do not answer with reproach but groan bitterly and call on God, you have at once put away all guilt. What could be happier? What easier for wiping out sins? But lest we seem to stir you only with human words, we will bring testimony from divine Scripture, so you may doubt no further. There were a Pharisee and a publican; the latter had sunk to the depths of wickedness, the former practiced the height of outward justice—giving his goods, fasting continually, free from rapine—while the other had spent his whole life in rapine and violence. Both went up to the temple to pray. The Pharisee stood and said, I thank you, Lord, that I am not as other men, rapacious, greedy, nor even as this publican (Luke 18:11-12). The publican

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stood far off; he did not return the insult, nor answer with reproach, nor say those vulgar things: Do you dare speak of my life and blame my deeds? Am I not better than you? I will report your sins and keep you from ever entering these sacred courts. None of those cold retorts that we daily hurl at one another did the publican utter; but sighing bitterly and striking his breast he said only, God, be merciful to me a sinner (Luke 18:13), and went down justified.

Do you see the speed? He took in reproach and washed reproach away; he acknowledged sins and put sins aside: accusation of guilt became remission of guilt for him, and the enemy, without knowing it, became a benefactor. How many labors had the publican to undergo—fasting, sleeping on the ground, keeping watch, giving his goods to the poor, sitting long in sackcloth and ashes—to lay aside sins so many and so long unpunished? But now, though he did none of that, with one simple word he put away all wickedness; and the Pharisee's reproaches and insults, which seemed to heap contempt on him, won him the crown of righteousness—without sweat, without toil, without long delay. Do you see that we too, if someone speaks truth about us—things of which we are conscious—and we do not answer the truth-teller with curses but groan bitterly and call on God for our faults, can put away all sins? In this way he was justified: for the publican did not return insult for insult against the Pharisee, but groaned over his own sins, and went down justified rather than the other.

5. Do you see how much good enemies' reproaches bring, if only we bear them with a philosophical mind? If both liars and truth-tellers help us, why do we grieve? Why do we burn? Unless you harm

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yourself, O man, neither friend nor enemy—not even the devil—can hurt you. For when those who insult us, who slander us, who plot against us even to the danger of our lives, still do us good—some weaving martyrdom's crown, as we showed, others by reproaching our sins making us righteous, as with the publican—why do we rage and flare up at them? Let us not say, He provoked me terribly, he drove me to shameful words: we are always the cause of such things. If we choose to live philosophically, not even a demon can stir us to anger. That is clear from many deep lessons and from this story of David now in our hands, worth bringing out today once we remind your charity where we lately stopped preaching. Where did we stop? At David's defense. So today we must tell you Saul's words, to see how he answered that most just defense. We shall see David's virtue not only in what David said but in Saul's reply: if Saul answered calmly and gently, we credit David, who changed the man, taught him, and composed his mind to sobriety. What did Saul say? After he heard David—Behold the hem of your cloak in my hand (1 Samuel 24:13), and all his defense—he said, Is that your voice, my son David (1 Samuel 24:17)? What a sudden change! He who could not bear even to speak his plain name, who hated the very mention of him, now took him as kin and called him son. What could make David happier—who made a father of a murderer, a sheep of a wolf, who filled wrath's furnace with dew, who turned storm into calm, who quenched every swelling surge of a mind boiling with anger? David's words, entering that fierce man's heart, wrought the whole change, as Saul's own words show. He did not say, Are these your speeches, my son David? but, Is that your voice, my son David?—so quickly did he warm to the voice itself. As a father, hearing his son's

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voice after long absence, is stirred not only at seeing him but at the very sound, so Saul, as soon as David's words entered his mind, cast off enmity, recognized the saint, put away one disposition and took up another. Anger laid aside, he received peace and pity. While night lasts we often fail to know a friend beside us; when day breaks we recognize his face even from afar. Enmity works the same way: while we harbor ill will, the voice we hear sounds wrong and we see the face through a distorted mind; but when anger is put away, the voice once hateful and hostile seems gentle and most sweet, and the look once hostile and unpleasant becomes dear and welcome.

6. When anger is loosed, we plainly see what did not appear while anger was boiling. David's voice was most powerful. The same thing happens in a storm: the mass of clouds does not let the sky's beauty show clearly to us; and though our eyes are keen, we cannot reach that heavenly splendor. But when the sun's heat breaks and scatters the clouds and reveals the sun, the sky's beauty appears again. The same happens in us when anger boils: while resentment stands like a dense cloud before eyes and ears, voices and faces seem other than they are. But as soon as someone has lived philosophically, put hatred away, and stripped off the cloud of grief, then at last with an uncorrupted mind he can quench all that bitterness. For what man famous for philosophy has anger not first blinded?

7. Nothing is more powerful than gentleness. To calm anger lies in our power. So you—whenever an enemy falls into your hands—must not look to how you may avenge him and send him off drenched in insults, but how you may heal him and bring him back to sober mind; and do not stop doing and saying everything until

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your meekness has overcome his savagery. For nothing is more powerful than gentleness. Someone showed this, saying, A mild word breaks bones (Proverbs 25:15). What is harder than bone? Yet if a man is utterly hard, stiff, and unyielding, the one who deals gently with him will easily win. And again, A gentle answer turns away wrath (Proverbs 15:1). Hence whether an enemy is provoked or reconciled is more in your power than his. It depends not on those who are angry, but on us, whether their anger is quenched or the blaze stirred hotter. Scripture made this plain with a simple example: if you blow on a spark you fan the fire; if you spit on it you put it out—and both are in your hand (Sirach 28:14, for both, it says, come from your mouth). So in quarrel with a neighbor: if you offer swollen, senseless words, you stir his fire and kindle coals; if you offer gentle, measured words, you will quench all anger before it flares. Do not say, I suffered this or heard that—when all of it is in your power. In you lies whether, like a spark, you quench anger or kindle it, calm rage or rouse it. When you see your enemy, or recall how many grievances you heard and endured, forget them all; and if you remember, lay them at the devil's charge. Rather collect anything he ever said or did that was humane. Dwell on that, and you will end enmity quickly. If you mean to accuse and remonstrate with him, first drop passion, quench anger, then remonstrate, then rebuke—you will win easily. Angry, we can neither speak nor hear anything sound; but free from turmoil we neither speak harshly ourselves nor take others' harsh words the same angry way. It is not so much the nature of words as a mind full of hatred that exasperates us. Often the same insults, heard from joking friends or little children, do not vex us—we even laugh and cheer up—because we

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do not hear them with a corrupted disposition or a mind already seized by anger. Likewise with enemies: quench anger, cast out hatred, and no words can wound you.

8. The wrongdoer is more worthy of tears. Why do I speak only of words? Let not even deeds provoke you, as nothing of the kind provoked this blessed man. When he saw the enemy armed against his life and, for that end, leaving no scheme untried, he was not only not angered but grieved for Saul's woes: the harder Saul plotted, the more David wept for him. He knew—knew for certain—that not the injured but the injurer deserves tears and lament, as one who hurts himself. So he made a long defense before him and did not stop until he moved his enemy to confess with tears and groans. After Saul wept, cried bitterly, and wailed aloud, hear what he says: You are more righteous than I, for you have repaid me good, but I have repaid you evil (1 Samuel 24:18). See how he condemns his own wickedness, proclaims the just man's virtue, and clears himself without anyone forcing him? Do the same yourself. When an enemy is in your hands, do not accuse him; cleanse your own heart, so you may lead him to condemn himself. If we accuse him, he grows fierce; if we show him mercy, he respects our gentleness and soon condemns himself. Then rebuke is free of suspicion and he sheds all malice. That is what happened here: the wronged man kept silent, and the wrongdoer vehemently accused himself. Saul did not simply say, You did me good, but, You repaid me good—that is: for ambushes, for murder, for those countless wrongs you repaid me great kindness. Yet I did not improve; after your kindnesses I stayed wicked. But you were not changed even so; you held your character steady, heaping benefits on us who were plotting against you again.

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In each of these phrases, how many crowns was David worthy of? Saul's mouth spoke them, but David's wisdom and skill had planted them in his mind. You have told me today what good you did me, since the Lord today shut me in your hands and you did not kill me (1 Samuel 24:19). Again Saul witnesses David's other virtue—that though he had earned praise he did not keep silent or hide it, but came forward and told it: not for display, but wanting by his acts to teach that he was among those who wish the king well and care for his good, not among plotters. Then it is right to recount one's own kindnesses, when great good is expected from it. Whoever, without cause, boasts and proclaims benefits done to another is no better than one who reproaches; but whoever does so to turn a hostile man with a bad opinion to the opposite is healer and benefactor—which David did, not chasing glory from Saul but trying to uproot anger rooted in him. So Saul praised him, because he had done well and had spoken of his merits.

Then especially sure rewards remain for us with God when men refuse them. Next, when Saul wished to repay the favor and could find nothing equal, he made God himself David's debtor in his own place, saying: If anyone finds his enemy in distress and lets him go on a good path, the Lord will repay him with good—as you have done to me today (1 Samuel 24:20). What could Saul return worthy of David's deeds, even if he gave the kingdom with every town? He had given not only towns and kingdom but his very life; David had no second life to give back. So he sends him to God and honors him by leaving repayment to God; and by praising David he teaches us all that greater rewards are stored with God when, for countless kindnesses to an enemy, we receive something quite different in

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return. After this Saul said: Behold, I know that you will surely reign, and that the kingdom of Israel will stand firm in your hand; and now swear to me by the Lord that you will not destroy my offspring after me or blot out my name from my father's house (1 Samuel 24:21-22). But tell me, I ask—how do you know this? With you are armies, money, arms, cities, horses, soldiers—in short, the whole royal apparatus; David here is destitute and bare, with no city, house, or household. Whence then do you say such things? Surely from David's character alone. Naked, unarmed, and alone, he could not have beaten me armed and ringed with such power unless he had God as helper; and whoever has God on his side is stronger than all. Do you see to what philosophy Saul was brought after the ambush? Do you see that an enemy can spit out all malice and, changed, turn back to what is better?

9. Let us not, then, lose heart about our salvation. For even if we have been brought to the very pits of wickedness, we can still call ourselves back from there and lay aside all malice.

What does he say next? Swear to me by God that you will not blot out my offspring after me, nor wipe out my name from my father's house (1 Samuel 24:21-22). The king asks a personal favor: the man crowned with a diadem plays the suppliant and begs an exile on behalf of his sons. This very thing shows David's virtue—that the enemy dared ask this of his enemy. He demands an oath not because he distrusts David's character, but because he counts how many wrongs he did him. Swear you will not destroy my offspring after me. He leaves the enemy as guardian for his sons and puts his own children into David's hands, and as he speaks, taking the hands of

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his sons and of David, he brings in God as surety. What then did David do? Did he meet this with pretense or irony? By no means: he at once agreed and granted the request. When Saul was dead, he not only spared his descendants but did more than he had promised. He brought Saul's son—lame in both his feet (2 Samuel 9:3, 10-13)—into his own house, made him share his table, and honored him greatly. He did not blush or hide it, nor think the royal table disgraced by the boy's lameness, but rather adorned and enriched. All who dined with him went away having learned great lessons in virtue. When they saw Saul's son, who had done such evils to David, held in such honor by him, even those fiercer than wild beasts were shamed and blushing made peace with every enemy. Even if David had only ordered food provided elsewhere and set a fixed way of life, that would have been much; but to welcome him at his own table is supreme philosophy. You know it is not easy to love enemies' children. What did I say, love? Not to hate, not to persecute—that alone is great. Many, when enemies died, poured on their children the anger they had borne the fathers. Not so this generous, magnanimous man: he honored the living enemy, and when Saul died showed his children the same goodwill he had shown him. What table was holier than one ringed by the enemy's son—the enemy, I mean, who tried to kill him? What feast more spiritual, where so many blessings overflowed? Angels rather than a man seemed the host. To embrace and love the enemy's children, and the son of the man who so often tried to cut him off and died still plotting—that act turns all praise back upon him. Do likewise, beloved: care for the children of the living and the dead. For the living, you will win their parents; for the dead, by tending their sons

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you will gain much favor with God and many crowns, and countless prayers from all—not only from those you helped but from those who only saw. That will stand for you on that day; great advocates at the judgment will be enemies you aided. You will wipe out many sins and claim your reward. Though you committed innumerable sins, if you offer the prayer, Forgive your enemies, and your Father will forgive your sins (Matthew 6:14), you will obtain remission of all with confidence and meanwhile live here in good hope, with everyone well-disposed toward you. When they see you love enemies and enemies' children like this, how can they fail to want to be your friends and devoted to you, doing and suffering all things for your sake? With so much favor from God, with everyone praying every good for you, what trouble will you feel? Who lives happier than you? Let us praise these things not only in this life but, when we go forth, keep them: go about seeking enemies to reconcile them to us and make true friends of foes. If we must apologize and ask pardon from them, let us not refuse, even when we were wronged. In this way we shall have richer reward, greater confidence, and without doubt win the kingdom of heaven, by the grace and goodness of our Lord Jesus Christ, with whom to the Father together with the Holy Spirit be glory, dominion, and honor, now and always, and unto ages of ages. Amen.